

# LEARN TO BE BAD AT STUFF

Today, I want to put my hand on two shoulders. The first is the former gifted child who breezed through school and college with little effort, only to arrive at university and suddenly discover that being 'smart' is no longer enough. The second is someone feeling like an impostor, convinced that they don't belong at university and that everyone else is somehow smarter, more capable, or better prepared. If you see yourself in either of them, this article may help you. Because despite how different these two students seem, they are often suffering from the same misunderstanding.

If I asked you to picture a 'good student', what would you imagine? Chances are, you would picture someone who never fails. Someone who consistently gets good grades, understands every lecture immediately, and rarely struggles with anything. That image is deeply ingrained in our

culture. So, for those of us who spent years being praised as 'good students' by a flawed system, failure became something to run from rather than something to learn from.

The system taught us that failure is not an option. And if failure is not an option, then the safest strategy is to avoid situations where failure is a possibility. We choose courses we know we'll do well in. We avoid competitions because someone else might be better. We don't ask questions because they might sound stupid. We don't start projects because we don't know how they'll turn out. We unknowingly shift our objective from becoming the best possible version of ourselves to protecting the fragile image of being someone who already knows everything.

Ironically, that's almost the opposite of how learning actually works. Failure is one of the most powerful forms of

feedback. Every mistake tells you that your current understanding is incomplete and points you toward what needs to change. If you've ever trained a machine learning model, this idea may sound familiar. A model updates its parameters based on how much its predictions differ from the expected output. If the loss is zero, there is nothing to learn.

Human learning isn't exactly identical, but it follows the same intuition. Learning, by definition, is the process of becoming able to do something you couldn't do before. Whether it's machine learning or human



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learning, poor performance in the early stages is inevitable and must be accepted as a necessary part of progress. Challenge is uncomfortable precisely because it exposes the gap between what we know and what we don't. Without that gap, learning is impossible.

**"If you only do what you can do, you will never be more than who you are now."**

*Master Shifu, Kung Fu Panda 3*

One thing university can offer you that schools and colleges rarely do is uncertainty. For the first time, there isn't always a model answer to memorize or someone to hand you the optimal weights. You have to experiment, make mistakes, question your assumptions, and gradually figure things out on your own.

For years, you may have been taught that being good at something meant succeeding on the first try. But understand that the opposite is usually true. If you're immediately good at something, you're probably doing something you've already learned. If you're terrible at it, confused, and constantly making mistakes, that's usually a sign that you've wandered into the territory where real learning can happen.

If your entire education taught you to avoid failure, then learning to fail again might be the

**I do not understand calculus YET.  
I'm not good at programming YET.  
I cannot speak in front of people YET.  
I am not creative enough YET.  
I have no idea what to write in a magazine article YET.**

most important lesson you'll ever learn. That uncertainty is a gift. It teaches you that failure isn't a verdict - it's feedback. It teaches you that struggling with something doesn't mean you're not built for it; it usually means you're learning something genuinely new. Most importantly, it teaches you that almost anything is learnable if you're willing to spend enough time being bad at it before becoming good.

So take the interesting course that intimidates you. Build something you've never built before. Join the club where everyone seems more experienced than you. Ask the question that feels embarrassing. Look at life like a game and treat every setback as a gain of EXP.

Be willing to look like a beginner, because beginners become masters. People who refuse to be beginners rarely become anything else. And please don't be too attached to who you are now. Give your future version a chance. Maybe that's what your years in university are really for. Not to prove how much you already know, but to discover how many things you're willing to be bad at.